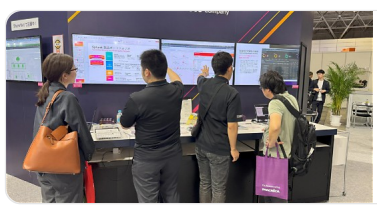
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Gary Larson uses numerous familiar situations in *The Far Side* to create humor available to a broad audience. Of his many relatable themes, one of the most endearing involves pets. While the series is known for incorporating dark humor, comics featuring pets are surprisingly lighthearted.


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Pets are sources of comfort, entertainment, and pleasant distraction. They are also typically loyal and make great companions. Larson's use of satire and exaggeration makes their inclusion in *The Far Side* a sound source of comedy for readers of all ages, and reveals just how important pets can be in keeping one's life from becoming dull.

Pets Reside In Strange Places In The Far Side

Publication Date: July 16, 1990

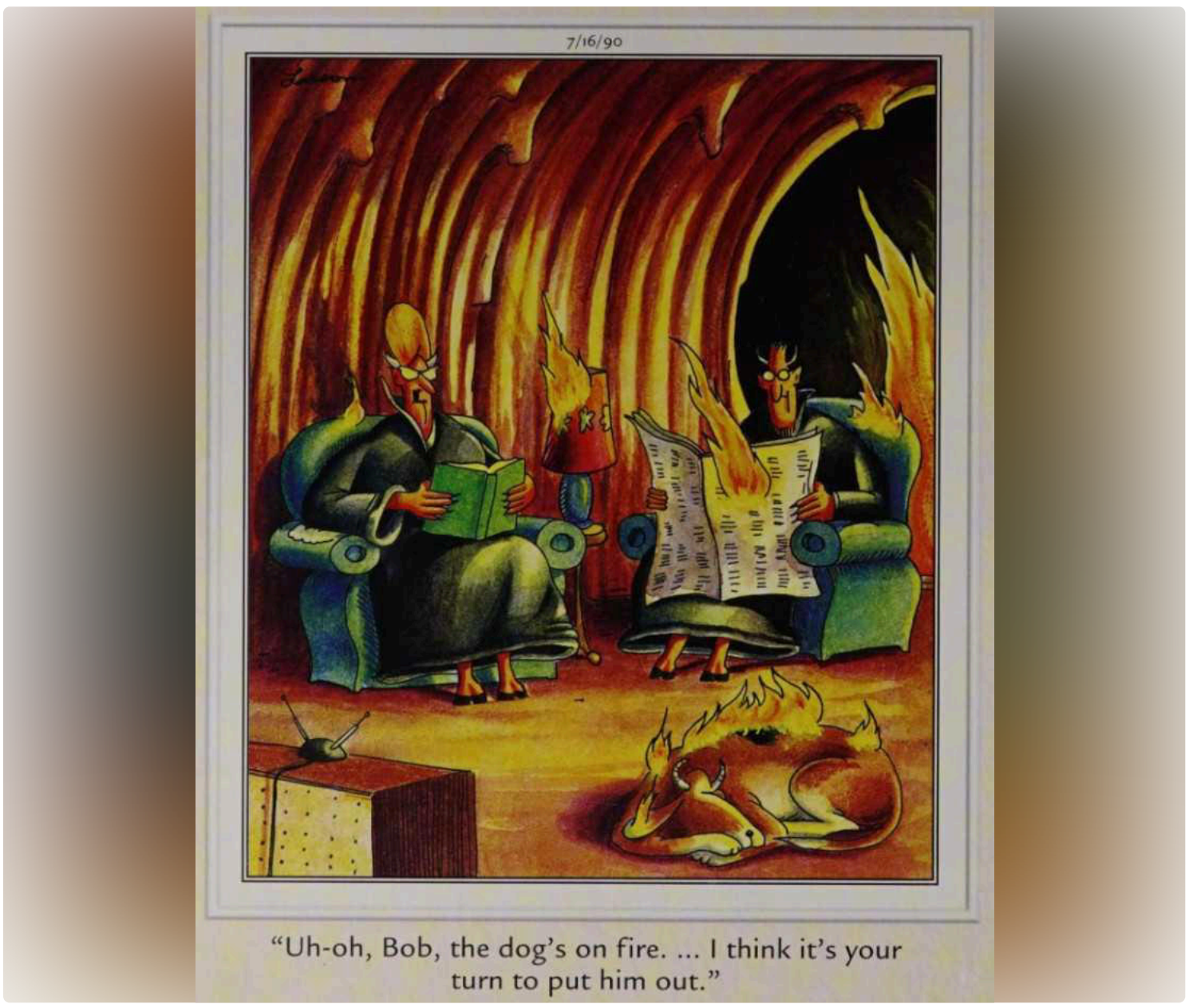
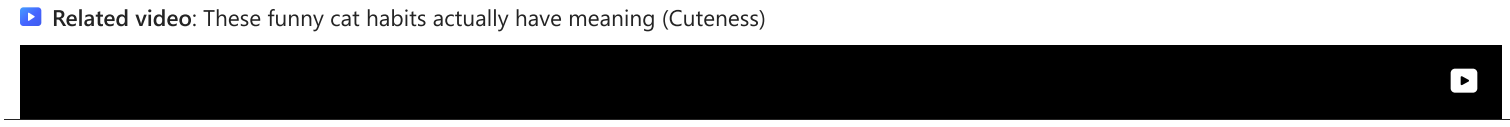
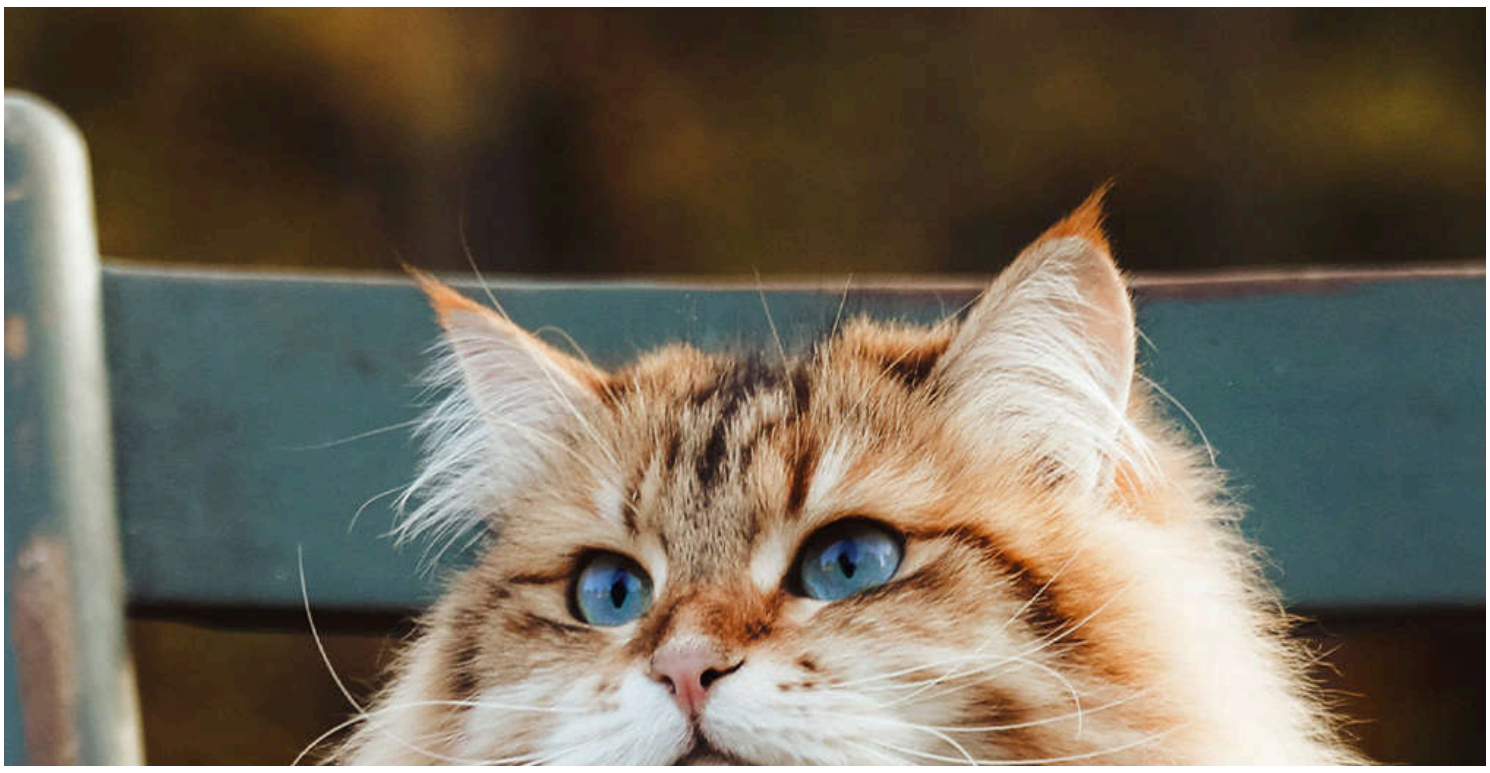


Image by Gary Larson

A pet in hell might normally seem out of place, but not so in *The Far Side*. Many of the demons featured in the series have pets, such as the ones depicted in Larson's flame-filled illustration. Larson's gag parodies the shared responsibilities that come with having an animal. Although this particular dog likely requires a bit more work than most.

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The joke's success stems from techniques employed that prevent readers from misunderstanding the scenario. Larson's addition of horns to the dog and its body language inspires laughter while letting readers know that the animal is alright. Still sleeping soundly implies the pet isn't all that bothered by the flames, which adds to the humor and makes the situation more relatable.

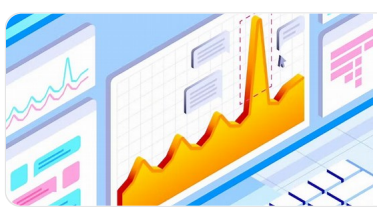
The Far Side Shows How Uncommon Pet Tricks Are Exciting

Publication Date: April 10, 1986



Image by Gary Larson

Pet tricks are an excellent source of entertainment. An unusual event in *The Far Side* reveals how exciting their behavior can be when it comes unexpectedly. Some tricks are more difficult than others, such as the depicted man having a fish jump up and rest on his finger. The fish's accomplishment uses shock to create humor. Few would have anticipated the act to be possible, let alone featured in a comic strip's gag.


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Despite the odd nature of the scene, readers can relate to the excitement felt when a pet gets down a tough trick for the first time. An abundance of hard work and repetition is involved, making the outcome gratifying. Larson's illustration incites thoughts of similar situations and feelings, albeit probably not with a fish.

The Far Side Explains Why Pets Stare Out The Window

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Publication Date: May 6, 1993

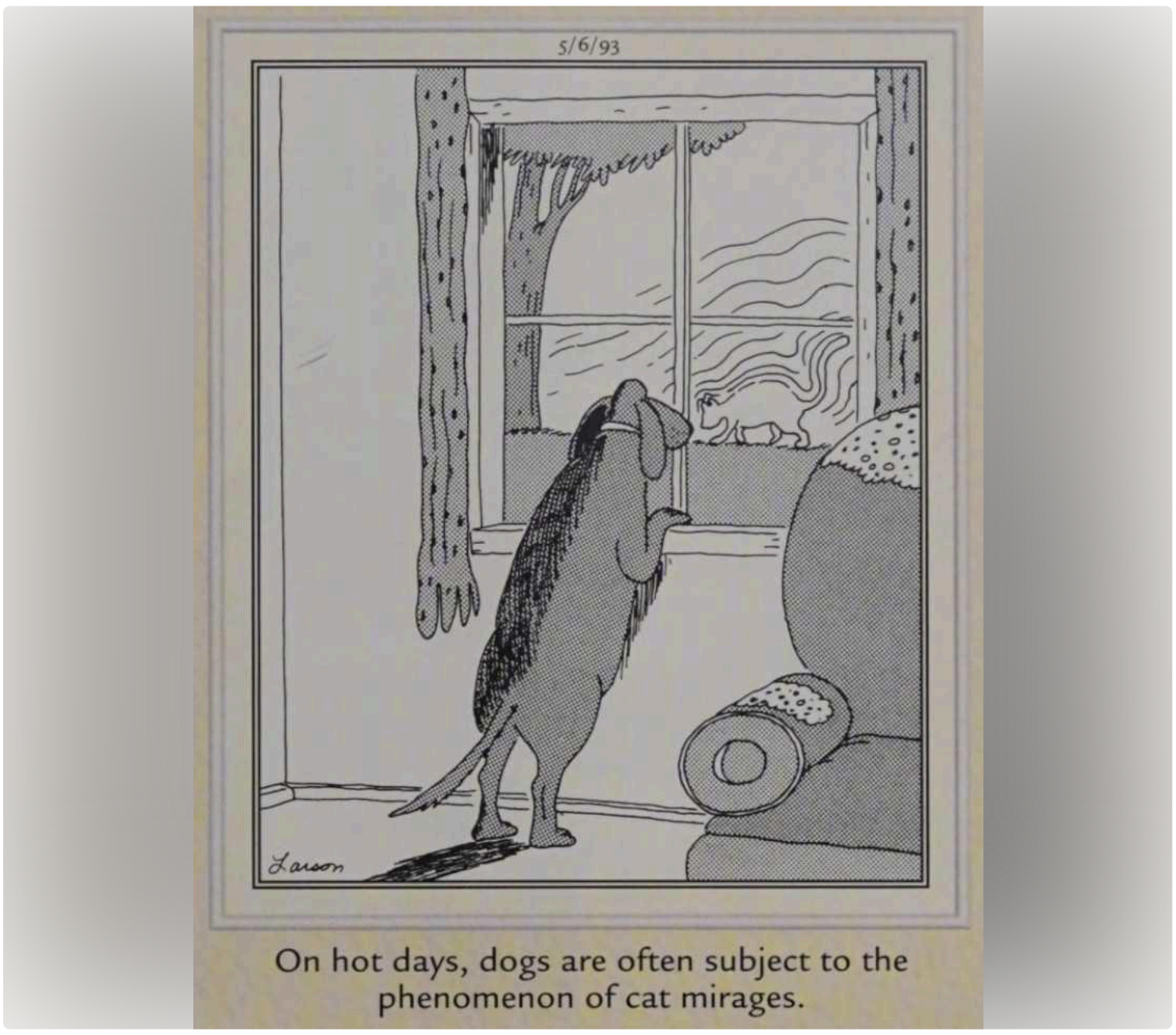


Image by Gary Larson

The Far Side contains many humorous depictions of canines. One of the more lighthearted of these comics is also surprisingly insightful. Many people wonder why their pets stare out the window when there doesn't seem to be anything of interest outside. Larson's answer to this query is interesting, to say the least. The cat mirage distracting the dog is a humorous but legitimate theory.


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Heat waves often play tricks on the eyes, being a primary source of mirages. Larson uses curved lines to represent this concept, effectively showing how they can lead to seeing things that aren't there. The stillness of the scene suggests that the animal is completely immersed in the sight, reminding readers of similar, hilarious occurrences with their pets.

Animals Are Adorable When Imitating People

Publication Date: March 23, 1984

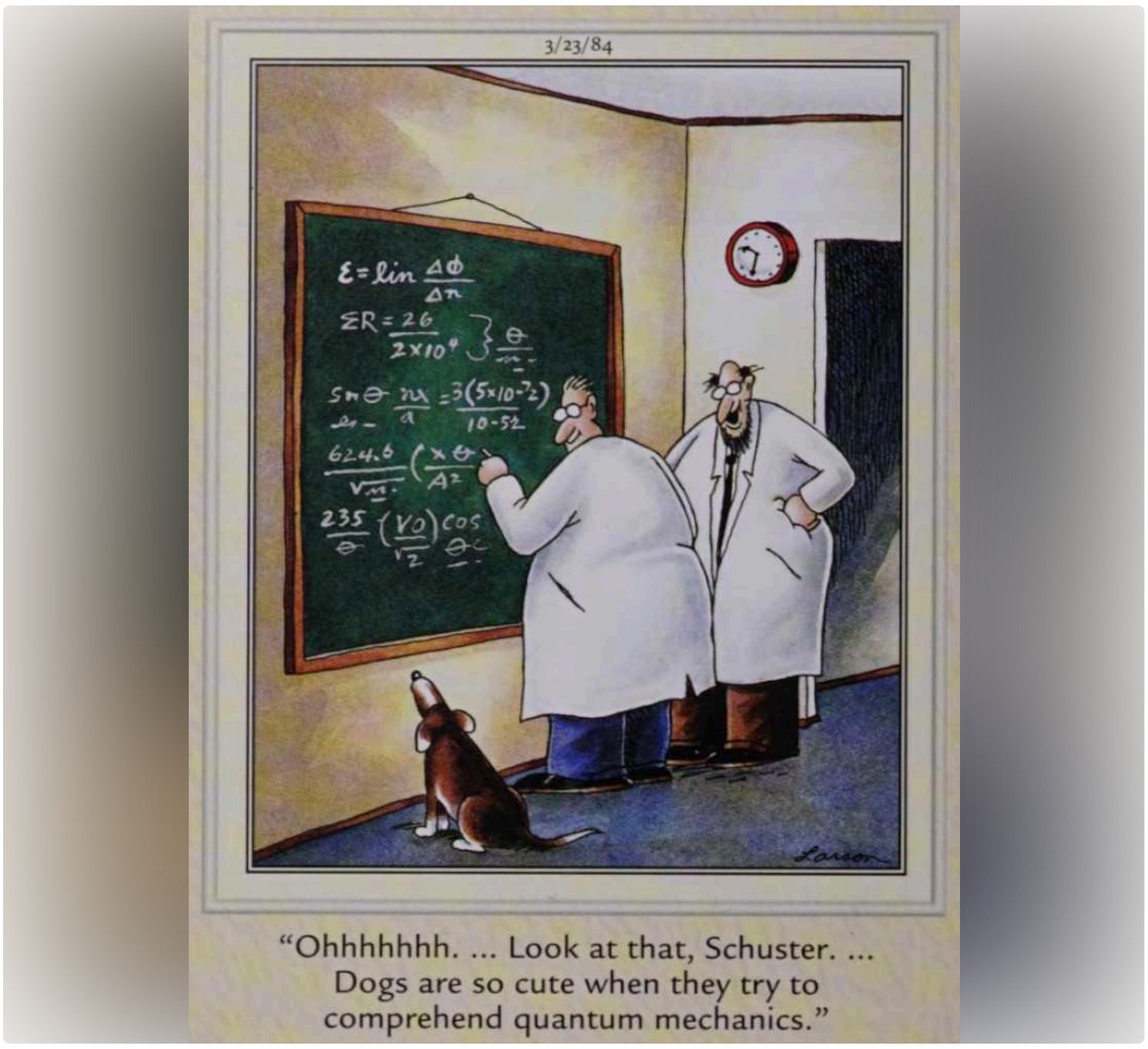


Image by Gary Larson

There's no denying that pets are adorable when imitating people. Animals attempting to engage in activities outside the realm of possibility always lead to humor. Larson takes advantage of this fact by using it as a source of comedy in an unexpected situation. The mathematicians hard at work reflect the common thoughts of pet owners in similar scenarios.

Larson's comic exaggerates the concept to the extreme. A key to effective humor is maintaining believability with this over-the-top style. By having the dog examine the board instead of working on it, the comic remains realistic and relatable. The text within the captions further supports the entertainment value of the strip by extending the time it takes for readers to reach the punch line, making it more impactful.

People Get Lonely Without Their Pets

Publication Date: Aug. 6, 1984

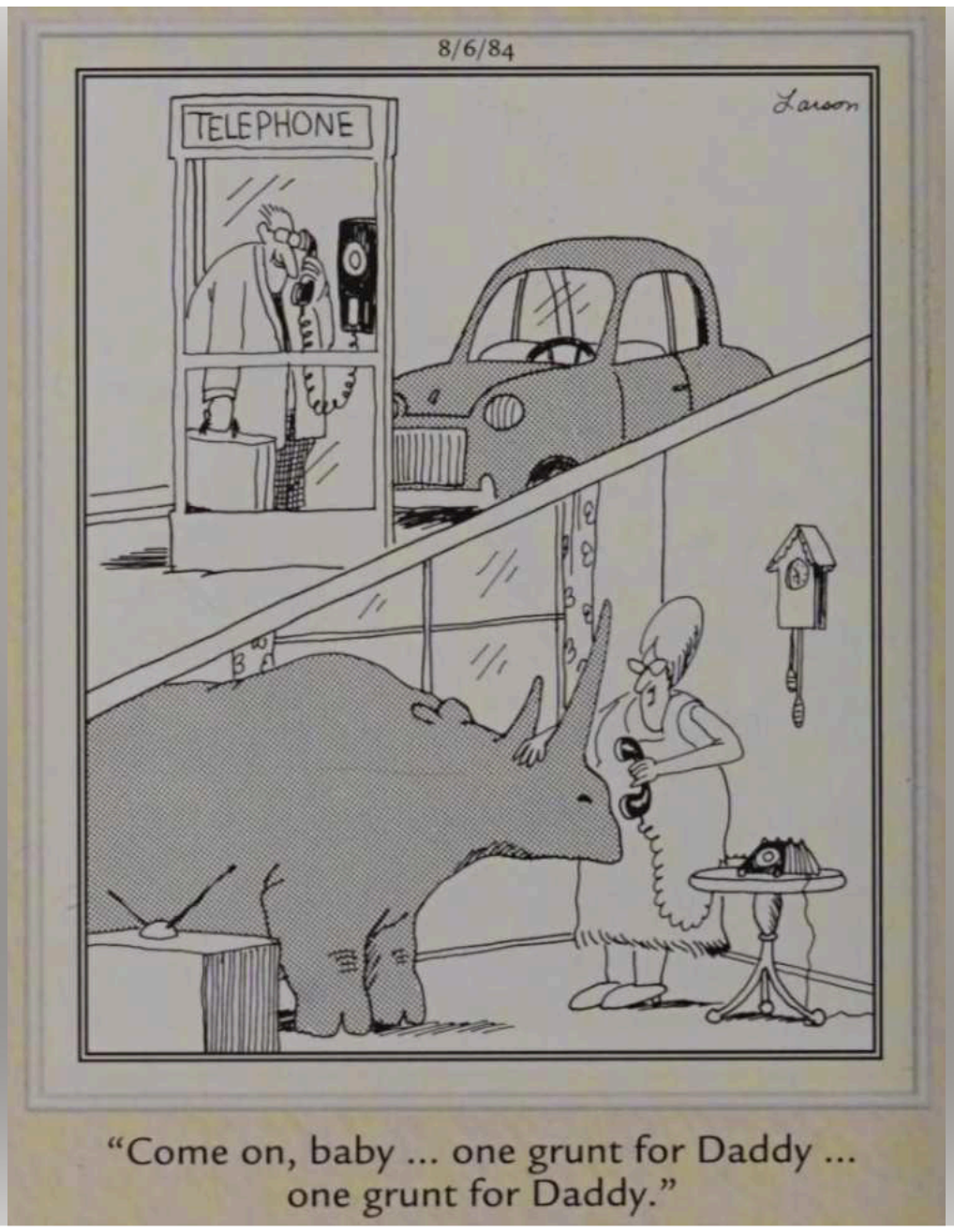


Image by Gary Larson

Taking a trip that demands the pet stay at home can make for a lonely journey. Pet owners in this situation often call home to check in and hear their companion's voice. If possible, that is. Most pets have no clue what's expected of them when they see a phone. The captions reflect the reader's experience humorously. Larson's use of a rhino as a pet suggests that the issue is present regardless of the type of animal.

The comic uses universal experience among pet owners to craft an entertaining situation. Most of the audience can connect with the concept, made hilarious by replacing a common pet with one not typically seen. While not the funniest of the bunch, the strip is widely available and appropriate for all ages.

Far Side Pets Need Friends Too

Publication Date: June 28, 1982



Image by Gary Larson

When new neighbors move in, pet owners have high hopes for the newcomers to have an animal that can play with theirs. Another Far Side rhinoceros owner gets incredibly lucky when her new neighbor exits the truck with the same kind of animal. The rhino's wagging tail speaks volumes, letting readers know it's overjoyed at the sight of a possible friend.

There are many strange types of pets in *The Far Side*, but only a few rhinos. As such, the odds of the situation depicted happening are slim. A point that Larson intentionally makes to connect the idea to reality. After all, the likelihood of someone moving in next door with the same type of pet isn't high enough to merit the hope it receives. Not to mention that even when the situation occurs, there are no guarantees that the animals will get along.

Far Side Pets Play Mean Pranks

Publication Date: Oct. 18, 1986



Image by Gary Larson

Many pets seem to enjoy pulling pranks on their companions. Most animal owners insist their pets go out of their way to play jokes on them. Larson's illustration provides a sound example of this type of behavior, accompanied by an entertaining look into what people's pets might be thinking. Considering the many incidents noted by pet owners, Larson might be on to something.

Animals are known for being playful, so a pet pulling a prank isn't that far-fetched. Canines are especially energetic and get bored easily. As such, dogs deciding to entertain themselves in the way shown makes sense. The comic uses this familiar scenario to create suggestive comedy. Fans know full well what comes next, and because of the dog's statement of intention, are highly amused.

Far Side Residents Enjoy Playing With Their Pets

Publication Date: Oct. 29, 1983

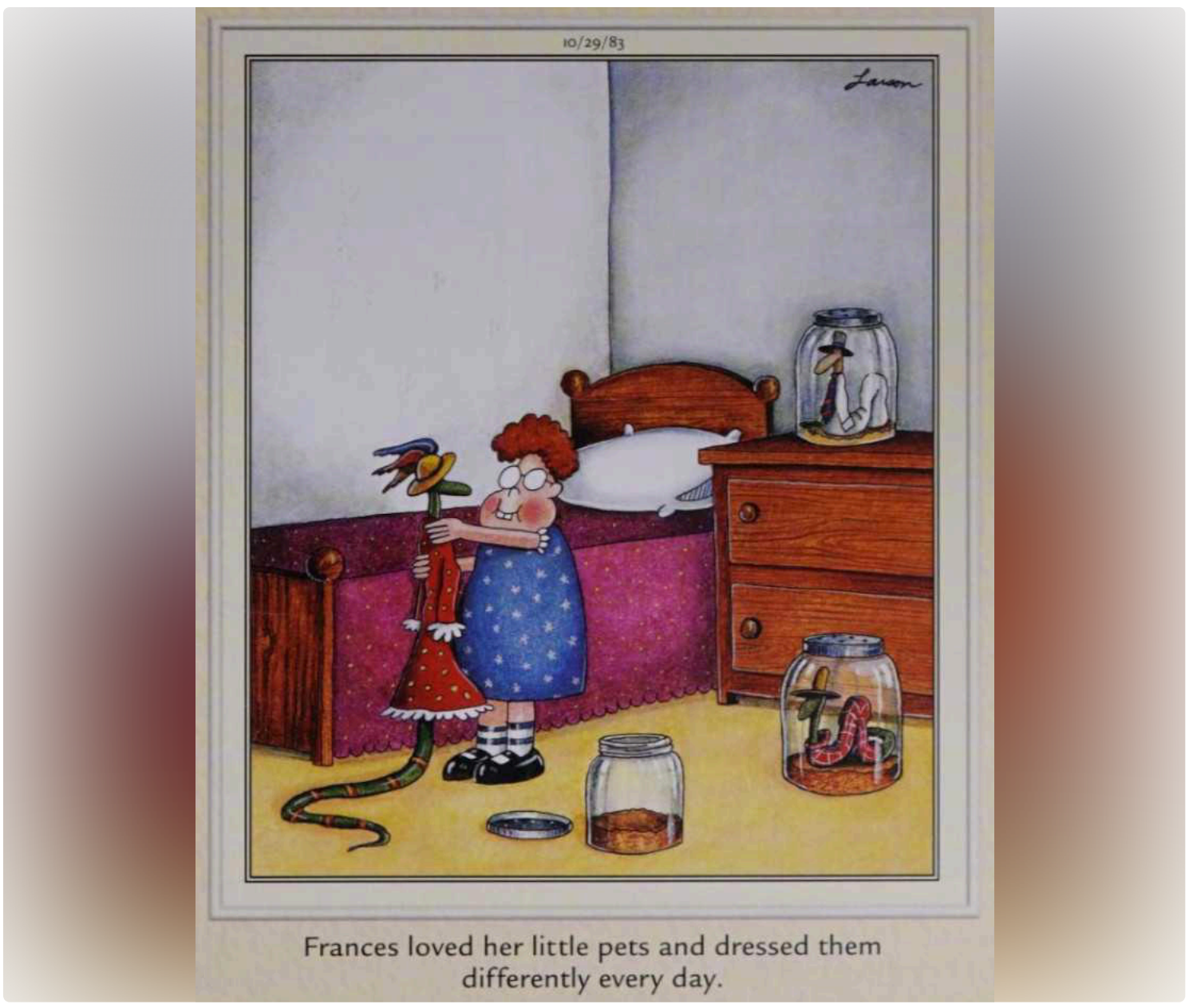


Image by Gary Larson

Dressing up one's pets is fairly common, especially with children. *The Far Side*'s take on the matter shows that there are no limits when it comes to what kind of animal can partake in the activity. The comic also creates comedy with Larson's unique style of irony. A snake is about the last animal readers would expect to find playing a game of dress-up.

Other than the bare walls, the strip is detailed well. The wood of the bed and dresser looks pristine thanks to Larson's imitative lines and shading. An illusion of reflection given to the glass adds an element of realism. Because of the amount of labor placed on the artistic design, the comic is as pleasing visually as the gag is amusing.

There Are Downsides to Being a House Pet

Publication Date: Oct. 20, 1982

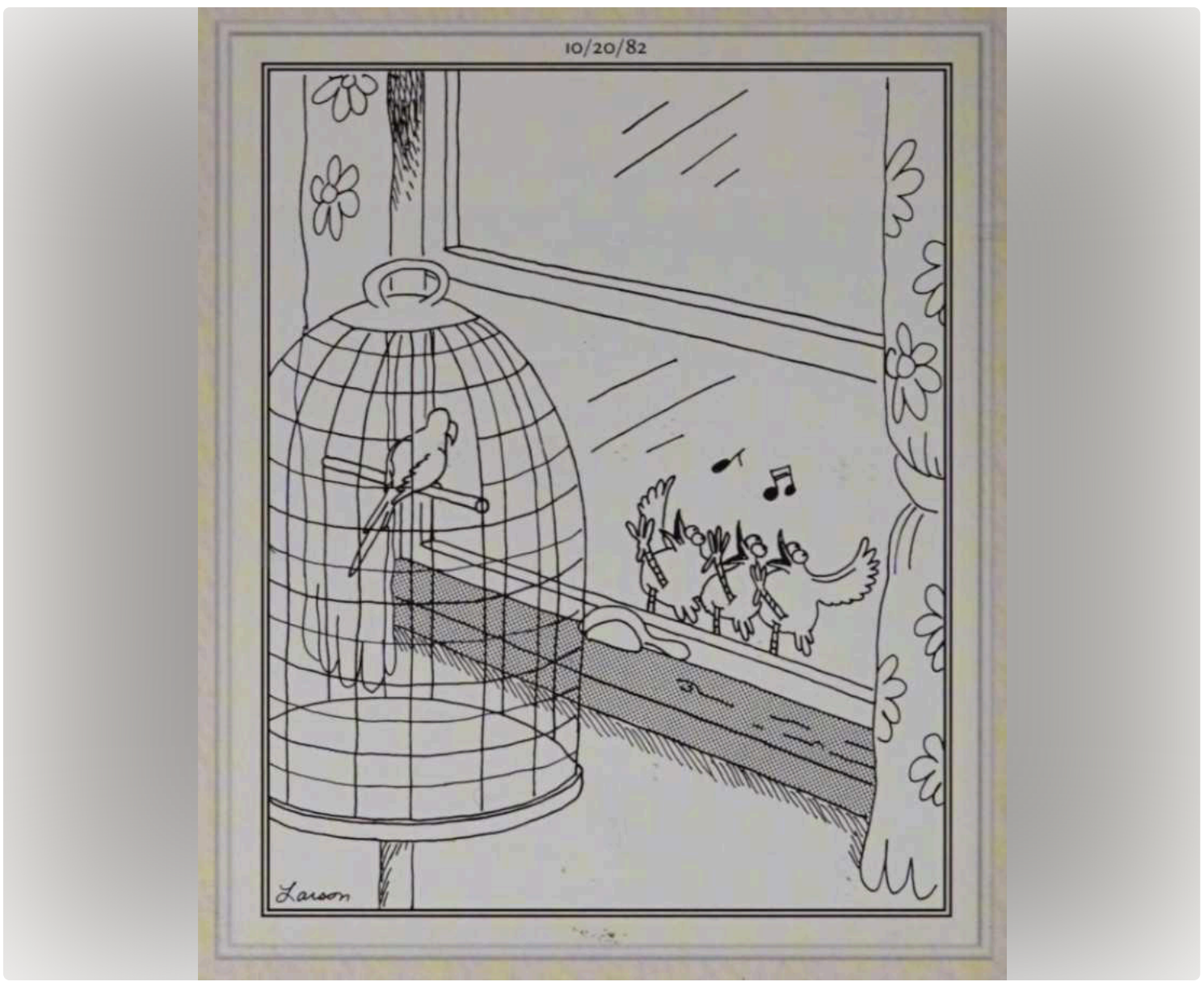


Image by Gary Larson

Animals sometimes have strange ways of teasing each other. An odd concept, but one that many pet owners will attest to. A hilarious installment of *The Far Side* gives a perfect example, albeit a bit exaggerated for comedic effect. The expressive mannerisms of the birds imply poking fun. The bird

in the cage would love nothing more than to join them.

Despite lacking color, the illustration paints a clear picture of the scene. The wide eyes, raised legs, and open mouths of the birds outside represent joyous motion. An act that makes little sense unless they are teasing the one trapped inside. The comic presents outstanding, relatable humor, but it does have one downside. Most readers can't help but feel bad for the caged bird.

The Far Side Shows That Tricks Should Be Catered to Pets

Publication Date: Oct. 6, 1981

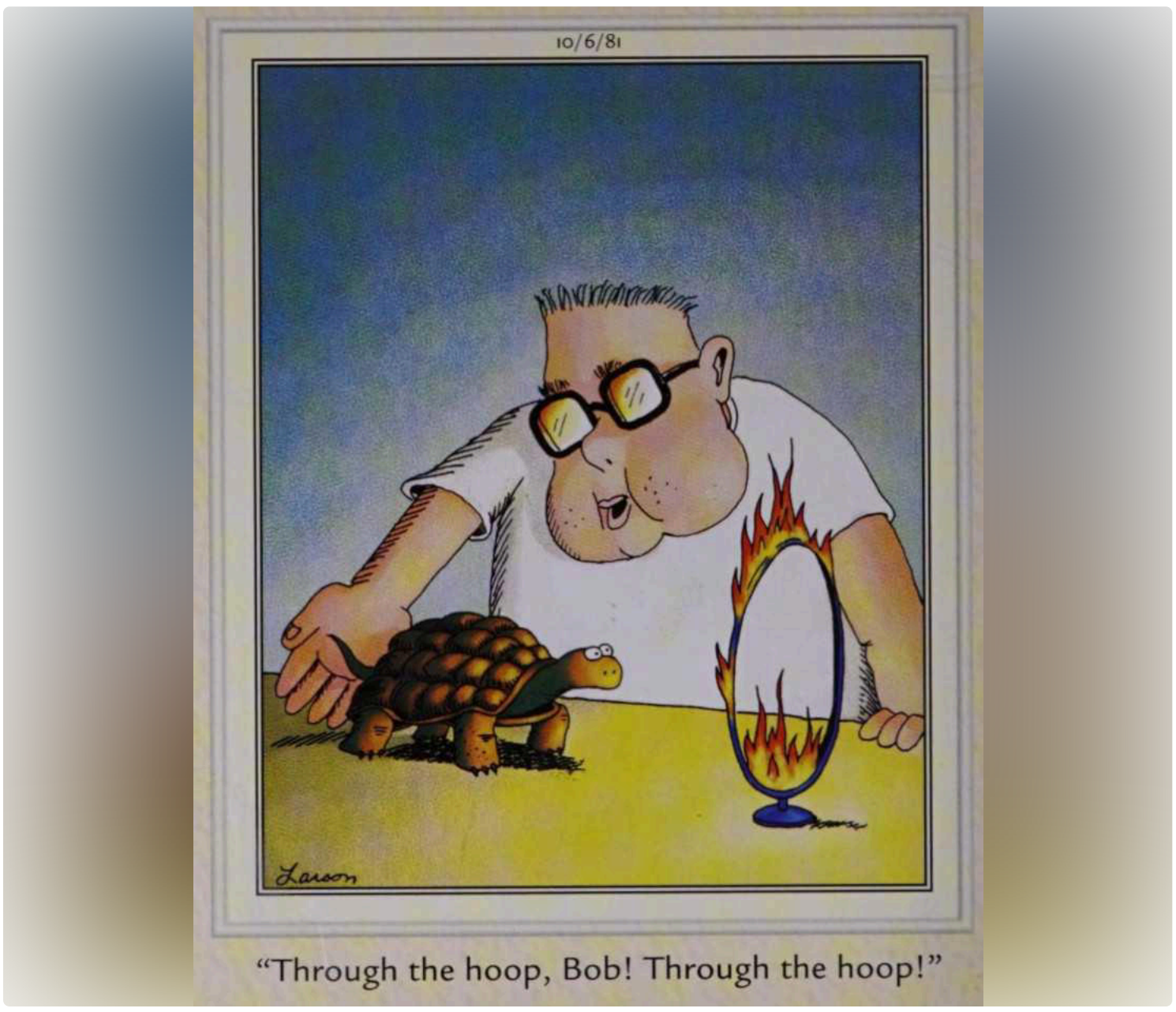


Image by Gary Larson

Pet owners love teaching their companions tricks. Most make sense, but *The Far Side* shows that some tricks are beyond the abilities of certain animals. Expecting a turtle to jump through a hoop, ablaze or not, might be a tad unrealistic. However, Larson's joke points to the common occurrence of pet owners expecting too much from their animals.

While the captions provide an amusing topper, the comic's backbone is found in Larson's artistic design. What makes the joke humorous and widely relatable are the minor details that add to the story. For example, the wide eyes of the turtle suggest fear. The boy's askew glasses imply a lower level of intelligence, which presents possible motivations behind the event. Finally, the shading on the left is in contrast with the bright light of the fire, implying intense heat.

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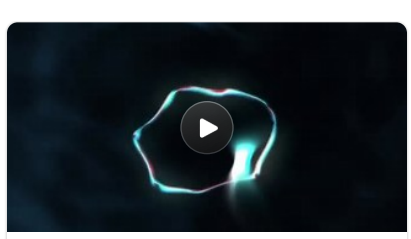
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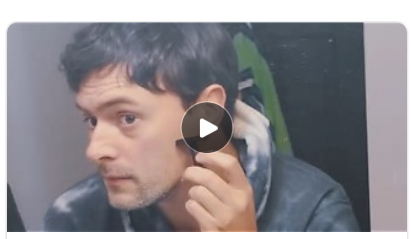
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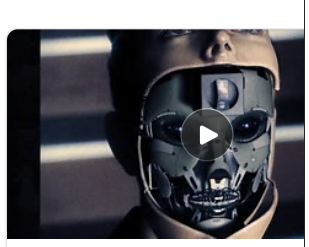




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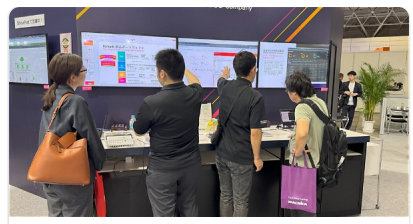


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Story by Taija PerryCook • 3d • ⏱ 4 min read



Poll workers demonstrate how ballots are are received, processed, scanned, and securely stored on Election Day at the Philadelphia Election Warehouse during a press tour by the Philadelphia City Commissioners on October 25, 2024 in Philadelphia, Pennsylvania. Matthew Hatcher, accessed via Getty Images.

Claim:

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Rating:

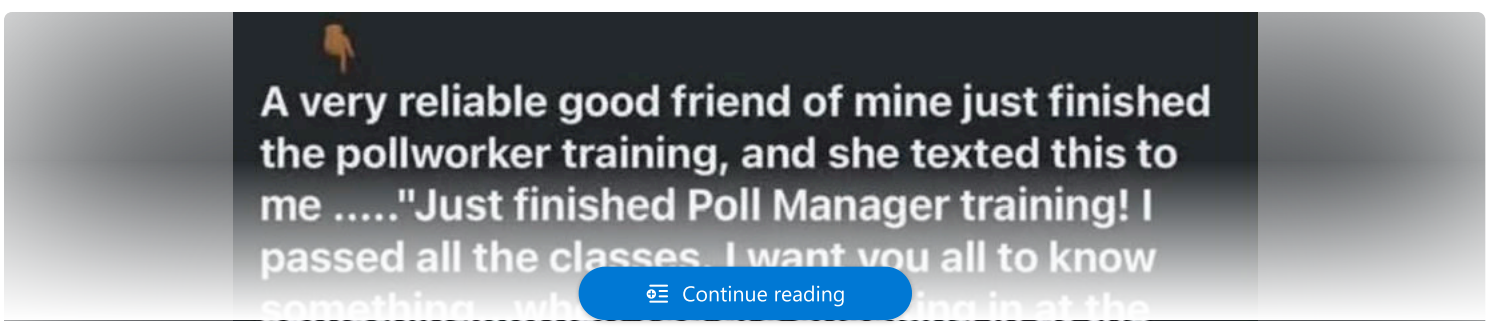
False (About this rating?)

> *Early voting in the U.S. midterm elections is underway. Voters are deciding which party will control Congress, as well as numerous state legislatures and governors' offices. Snopes' fact-checkers are flagging rumors surrounding the election, debunking false statements by candidates and suspicious voter fraud claims with nonpartisan research and expert sources. Join our effort to keep this election fact-focused by becoming a Snopes member.*

Ahead of the 2026 midterm elections, some social media users are warning that any election ballot marked by a poll worker could be disqualified, whether it is "a letter, a checkmark, a star, an R or a D any writing of any kind."

The rumor has spread on numerous occasions. Snopes addressed the claim before both the 2020 and 2024 elections. Posts typically feature the same copypasta, shown below (emphasis ours):

> A very reliable good friend of mine just finished the pollworker training, and she texted this to me ....."Just finished Poll Manager training! I passed all the classes. I want you all to know something...when you are checking in at the polls and they happen to write anything on your ballot before they give it to you to put in the voting machine...a letter, a checkmark, a letter star, an R or a D any writing of any kind...please request a new ballot. **Your ballot will be disqualified if it is written on.** Please be on the look out. Make sure poll workers do not write on your ballot. It will cause your ballot to be disqualified."
>
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